PACLAND · Checking a field that has nothing to check against

The oracles method, in plain words — for economics, climate, medicine, or any field whose future has not happened yet.

1 · The question

Physics can compare a claim with a measurement. Economics cannot measure the future it forecasts. So is a field like that simply unverifiable? No — and the mistake is assuming an oracle means “a measurement you go and find”.

2 · What we found

- An oracle is anything that can tell you a claim is wrong without you knowing the answer first. There are five kinds; measurement is only the most expensive.
- The bookkeeping kind: money has to add up, energy cannot vanish. A claim that breaks the arithmetic is wrong before anyone collects data.
- The relabelling kind: units, base years, price deflators, how you group the data. Change the description and the claim must not move. If it moves, it was about the description, not the world.
- The simplest-guess kind: “nothing changes”. Expensive models must beat it, and often they do not. On real-time data a textbook inflation forecast lost to the guess by 3%.
- The invented-world kind, and the sharpest: build a world where *you* wrote the answer, then demand the method find it. Ours couldn't — asked to recover a known value of 0.18, it answered 1.00.

3 · The best we have right now

Both of the cheap gates run green, on real data, with a deliberate fault proving each one can fail: the economics one on units, base years, deflators and parametrisation (4 of 4), the climate one on baselines, units and the choice of start years (3 of 3), and five invented-world checks on our own estimators (5 of 5). One of those checks corrected us: it showed our claim that a simple trend beats every climate model does not survive changing the start years.

4 · How we refine it

- Name the gap instead of papering over it: we have one archive of historical revisions, so we test around it rather than close it, and the report says so.
- When a field asks for more data, first ask which kind of problem it has. Sampling error shrinks with data. A mis-measured input does not: our check shows the same wrong answer at 1,600, 6,400 and 25,600 observations.

5 · What this means for the world

A field with no ground truth can still certify that its claims are internally consistent, do not depend on how the data was written down, and beat the simplest guess. That is a real label a regulator or a reader can use — and nobody issues it today.

6 · What this cannot do

It cannot produce a value that was never in the data. The interesting numbers in economics are not recoverable from totals, and no oracle among the five can conjure them. The honest output is the size of what is unchecked, not a number dressed up as knowledge.